C2 Grammar

Cleft sentences and fronting

Shift focus with 'It was … that' and 'What I need is …' for precise emphasis.

Cleft sentences split one idea into two clauses so that one element gets the spotlight. They are common in speech and in persuasive writing.

It-clefts

Pattern: `It + be + focus + that / who + rest`

Neutral: Maria sent the email on Monday.
It was Maria who sent the email on Monday.
It was on Monday that Maria sent the email.

Wh-clefts (pseudo-clefts)

Pattern: `What + clause + be + focus`

I need a long holiday. → What I need is a long holiday.
He lied to us. → What he did was lie to us.

Other focus devices

Device	Example
All … is / was	*All I wanted was a quiet evening.*
The reason why … is that	*The reason why it failed is that nobody tested it.*
Fronting	*Strange as it may seem, I enjoyed the exam.*
Reversed wh-cleft	*A long holiday is what I need.*

Use with care. Clefts imply a contrast. *It was Maria who sent it* suggests someone thought it was another person.

Practice

1. Focus on 'the noise': The noise annoys me most.
2. Focus on 'in 2010': We met in 2010.
3. Use 'All': I said that I was tired.
4. Use 'What ... did': She resigned.

▼ **Show answers**

1. What annoys me most is the noise. / It's the noise that annoys me most.
2. It was in 2010 that we met.
3. All I said was that I was tired.
4. What she did was resign.